



# Character Themes: Heroes of Cormyr

By Dan Anderson

*Illustrations by William O'Connor, Claudio Pozas, Goran Josic*

Developing your character into someone who has a rich story can be a fun and rewarding process. You likely have an idea of what race and what class you want to play, but you might have only a general idea of what your character's life was like before you start playing the character at the gaming table. A theme can help you flesh out your character and provide some options for developing his or her background.

This article details two character themes, the Purple Dragon and the Cormyrrian battle mage.

## PURPLE DRAGON

Many able-bodied men and women of Cormyr have taken the oath of sworn service to the Crown of Cormyr and earned the title of Purple Dragon. Although an exceptional few rise to knighthood and become Purple Dragon Knights, the Purple Dragons are those trained soldiers loyal to Cormyr who are ready to serve in times of war.

TM & © 2012 Wizards of the Coast LLC. All rights reserved.

All loyal citizens are eligible to take the oath of the Purple Dragon when they reach maturity. Those of noble lineage are expected to take the oath and typically are trained for positions of leadership, while those of a common bloodline sign up for two years of service in the militia and undergo extensive training.

A lucky few are accepted as squires to Purple Dragon Knights. A squire's crest is emblazoned on a background of the liege's color, and these backgrounds are as numerous as the shades of the rainbow, though the purple dragon crest is never displayed on a black field. Those in direct service to the royal family and those who do not serve a particular noble bear their crests on a white background.

Purple Dragons' training consists of three schools of focus. The young and fearless begin their study by learning attack techniques that bring the fight to the enemy. Those who dream of advancing through the ranks to take positions of leadership study tactics to best take advantage of the battlefield. The most respected are those who train to protect key personnel, especially War Wizards, and do not hesitate to sacrifice themselves for the greater cause. Regardless of role, the Purple Dragons train to fight together as a unit. Loyalty, duty, and honor are valued above all else, and a unit of Purple Dragons can operate as a single machine, utilizing the strengths of the working whole over the individual weaknesses of each component.

Purple Dragons spend six months in extensive training. They are then assigned to a specific location to continue training while on active duty. Some receive assignments to serve in a major city and maintain the king's law; the largest such garrisons are in Suzail and Marsember. Others maintain border patrols as a first line of defense against Cormyr's enemies. After two years of service, some Purple Dragons choose the defense of Cormyr and enforcement of her laws as a career, but most return

to their homes and professions until the need arises for them to bear arms in the name of the king. A rare few become adventurers, honing their skills so that they can be at their best when they are called back into service.

## Creating a Purple Dragon

Loyalty to crown and country are paramount for a Purple Dragon, so there are no restrictions on class or race for citizens of Cormyr, who are mostly human. Non-native races often need to demonstrate their loyalty to prove their intentions before taking the oath.

**Alignment Prerequisite:** The Purple Dragons welcome any of good or lawful good alignment who take the oath to serve Cormyr and her king above all personal desires, and those who vow to protect all

### CHARACTER THEMES

Your character's theme is a career, calling, or identity that describes who he or she is in the world. Just as race and class create basic definitions about who your character is, theme adds a third character component to help refine your story and identity. For example, if you're a human fighter who has the Purple Dragon theme, you might be a noble trained in the military, or have roots as a common farmer ready to bear arms in the militia to defend Cormyr. If you are a wizard or a sorcerer, you might have studied at the War Wizard Academy in Cormyr as an apprentice.

For information on using themes as part of character creation and rules for how to gain and use theme powers and features, see "Heroes of Nature and Lore," *Dragon* 399.





citizens of Cormyr. Betrayal of one's oath or another Purple Dragon is an act of treason. Those who enter into this vow lightly might one day dangle at the end of a hangman's noose!

## Starting Feature

During their training, Purple Dragons learn attack, defense, and tactical stances to enhance their fighting style. Most focus on mastering one style, though they can call upon their training for any of the three styles.

All Purple Dragons train with swords, quarter-staffs, spears, and myriad other weapons, since one never knows what will be available in times of need. Most brash recruits begin their study with attack forms, advancing wildly and forcefully to bring down their opponents quickly. The Purple Dragons' training harnesses that energy and enthusiasm to maximize the effectiveness of attacks while not exposing defenses unnecessarily. After months of training, a Purple Dragon can effortlessly improve his or her most common attack forms, without compromising other aspects of combat.

The second stage of training involves defense of others. Although most warriors can defend themselves in combat instinctively, protecting another while not shirking one's own defenses takes months of practice. Purple Dragons have the ability to interfere with the attacks of enemies that are aimed at their nearby allies.

Finally, battlefield positioning is ingrained in all Purple Dragons, whether commanding allies into advantageous positions or knowing instinctively how to follow orders. Working as part of a unit requires a Purple Dragon to be in an ideal position at all times.

**Benefit:** You gain the *focused discipline* power.

## Focused Discipline Purple Dragon Utility

*You call upon your training and adjust to the ebb and flow of battle, going on the offensive or falling back to defend yourself as the situation demands.*

**At-Will ♦ Martial, Stance**

**Minor Action Personal**

**Effect:** You enter the focused discipline stance. Until the stance ends, at the start of each of your turns you can choose one of the following benefits. The benefit lasts until the start of your next turn.

- ♦ **Offense:** You gain a +1 power bonus to melee basic attack rolls.
- ♦ **Defense:** Whenever you hit an enemy with a melee basic attack, one ally adjacent to you gains a +1 power bonus to all defenses until the start of your next turn.
- ♦ **Tactics:** After you hit an enemy with a melee basic attack, you can shift 1 square as a free action.

## Additional Features

### Level 5 Feature

Purple Dragons are trained to handle situations as a single unit. This expertise is not limited to combat, and as a Purple Dragon rises in personal experience, he or she learns to work well with teammates to overcome numerous challenges. When someone takes the lead in a task, a Purple Dragon knows just what to do to lend a hand.

**Benefit:** When you use the aid another action and succeed, you grant an additional +1 bonus to the aided check.

### Level 10 Feature

As Purple Dragons refine their *focused discipline* power, they master the basic styles of fighting. Their common attacks rival those that others can muster only once per encounter. The next step for Purple Dragons who reach this level of combat prowess is full knighthood, which requires completing a quest

on behalf of a noble or otherwise furthering the interests of Cormyr.

**Benefit:** Once per encounter, when you use *focused discipline*, you can choose a second benefit at the start of one of your turns. Both benefits last until the start of your next turn.

## Optional Powers

Purple Dragons train to fight as a team. Some choose powers to enhance their ability to work with others, which comes in handy when traveling with a group of adventurers.

### Level 2 Utility Power

As a Purple Dragon, you have been trained to work closely with your allies, which provides you with both the ability to spot a weakness in a foe's defense and point it out to your teammates.

## Exploit Opening Purple Dragon Utility 2

*Your enemy deflects your blow, and you notice a weakness that your allies can exploit.*

**Encounter ♦ Martial**

**Free Action Special**

**Trigger:** You miss an enemy with a melee attack.

**Effect:** The enemy grants combat advantage until the start of your next turn.

### Level 6 Utility Power

With only a few words, a tactically minded Purple Dragon can issue orders to reposition allies on the battlefield. Other Purple Dragons instinctively close ranks to face the enemy.

### Sudden Formation

Purple Dragon Utility 6

*As you bark a few short commands, your allies move into position.*

**Encounter ♦ Martial**

**Move Action** Close burst 5

**Target:** Each ally in the burst

**Effect:** You move up to half your speed. Each target can then shift up to his or her speed to a square adjacent to you as a free action.

### Level 10 Utility Power

Many Purple Dragons can use their training to warn allies of incoming attacks. The *unified resilience* power reflects how a Purple Dragon's warnings can turn a potentially devastating attack into a glancing blow.

### Unified Resilience

Purple Dragon Utility 10

*Using your knowledge of battle, you call out warnings to nearby allies, helping them to avoid solid blows.*

**Daily ♦ Aura, Martial**

**Minor Action** Personal

**Effect:** You activate an aura 1 that lasts until the end of the encounter. While in the aura, each ally who can hear you gains resistance to all damage equal to your highest ability modifier.

## OATH TO THE CROWN OF CORMYR

I solemnly swear to serve Cormyr and her interests above all else. I vow to answer any call from the crown, the royal family, recognized nobles, and citizens in need, to the best of my ability. I promise that in time of war, I will return to my sworn position and bear arms in service to crown and country.

## CORMYRIAN BATTLE MAGE

Although any magician can create fire or force effects to hinder foes, a battle mage studies the art of maximizing his or her devastating effectiveness under the watchful eye of an established War Wizard. Those who truly master the craft might be invited to join the order of Cormyr's War Wizards, the elite battle casters sworn to the crown of Cormyr.

The War Wizards of Cormyr are a secretive group. They realize that if the secrets they discover are shared only with those within their ranks, they gain an edge over their enemies. They reveal some of these secrets through research, and they find others in long-lost tomes of lore. Many War Wizards send their battle mage apprentices out with adventurers, with strict instructions to return and share any ancient secrets they might uncover. Like Purple Dragons, War Wizards and battle mages must swear an oath of fealty to Cormyr before training begins.

Most battle mages are recruited as children when they show aptitude after being introduced to arcane theories or if they exhibit a natural talent for the arcane art. Some students who excel at their studies after being recruited are tested by a War Wizard and, if special talent is identified, they are taken from their families to learn at the War Wizard Academy. Only a few of those who achieve the mastery of basic arcane practices are admitted to the academy formally and are assigned to a particular War Wizard as an apprentice. The others are returned to their families. Having one's child selected to study with the War Wizards is considered a great honor.

Once admitted, an apprentice spends five years studying the basic tenets of wizardry. Over half cannot achieve the high standards set by the War Wizards and are dismissed. After five years of successful study, an apprentice gains the benefits and



official title of battle mage. He or she then studies additional secrets unique to the War Wizards.

A few adults petition the War Wizards for an apprenticeship to learn their secrets and master their craft. The War Wizards are suspicious of such requests and turn away those who have not gained the full trust of the crown or proven themselves loyal citizens. Petitioners must undergo a series of divinations and other tests to verify their intentions. They must also prove their value to the organization by providing new knowledge of the arcane arts or by teaching a new and useful spell. Only then can a practicing wizard or sorcerer become the apprentice of a War Wizard. The expectations for all battle mages are the same, regardless of age.

After becoming a battle mage, some thus titled request a sabbatical to travel the world so that they can learn mystical secrets to bring back to the organization and strengthen it.

## Creating a Battle Mage

**Class Prerequisite:** Loyalty to crown and country is paramount for a battle mage. However, the War Wizards must also find value in the arcane arts that the apprentice brings to their organization. Only sorcerers and wizards can become Cormyrian battle mages.

**Alignment Prerequisite:** Any unaligned, good, or lawful good wizard or sorcerer who takes the oath to serve the realm, her king, and the War Wizards of Cormyr can become a Cormyrian battle mage. Breaking this oath is considered treason, and the organization will go to great lengths to prevent ex-members from revealing its secrets, most of which involve shaping spells on the battlefield and empowering spells to damage Cormyr's enemies.

## Starting Feature

Cormyrian battle mages gain a basic understanding of the philosophy and tenets of the War Wizards. They do not study magic for the sake of arcane knowledge, but focus specifically on how they can enhance magic in battle.

The first stage of study is to learn to defend oneself from attacks while casting. A battle mage can cast spells quickly and gracefully without lowering defenses.

Next, battle mages must understand how combat ebbs and flows. They learn to recognize the value of each combatant in a battle and learn to use their spells to destroy the enemy while not hindering their own forces. It is rare for battle mages to fight a lone battle or a wizard's duel, since their purpose is to enhance the Purple Dragons of Cormyr. Personal glory is of little interest to War Wizards, and they instill this outlook within their battle mage apprentices. Value is placed on honing one's instincts to react to a changing battlefield and shaping spells to avoid allies while devastating enemy forces.

Finally, each battle mage is taught to be alert at all times. Many tactical tomes advise that taking out the enemy's leadership and spellcasters first is the best way to win a battle. While engaged in conflict, battle mages are aware that they are high-value targets, and they do whatever it takes to protect themselves from harm. This is not a selfish act, rather it is a recognition that the loss of one's power is a significant blow to allies during a battle.

**Benefit:** You gain the *defensive casting* power.

### Defensive Casting Cormyrian Battle Mage Utility

*You use one of the secret incantations of the War Wizards to protect yourself when casting.*

**Encounter** ♦ **Arcane**

**Minor Action**

**Personal**

**Effect:** Until the end of your next turn, your ranged and area arcane powers do not provoke opportunity attacks.

## Additional Features

### Level 5 Feature

The War Wizards of Cormyr have entrusted you with some of the rare knowledge they have gathered about topics beyond the arcane.

**Benefit:** You gain a +2 power bonus to History checks and Religion checks.

### Level 10 Feature

As one's training nears its culmination, each battle mage becomes attuned to sense potential dangers. You have an uncanny ability to know when you are about to be attacked and can react accordingly. Your arcane senses keep you safe from sudden danger.

**Benefit:** You cannot be surprised.

## Optional Powers

A battle mage's training strongly encourages the use of offensive spells during mass combat. The secrets studied include ways to focus and shape arcane destructive power to maximize the effects on enemies while minimizing collateral damage to allies.

### Level 2 Utility Power

On a crowded battlefield, it is often impossible for an arcane caster to avoid targeting his or her allies. With some study, you have learned to utter incantations to adjust your spells and reduce the chance of striking your allies.

#### Irregular Dispersal

Cormyrian Battle Mage Utility 2

*You control the energy of your spells to avoid hitting your friends.*

**Encounter** ♦ **Arcane**

**Minor Action**

**Personal**

**Effect:** You take a -4 penalty to attack rolls against your allies until the end of your next turn.

## Level 6 Utility Power

While destructive arcane spells explode around the battlefield, battle mages can use a complex cantrip attuned to their spells that wards an ally from their effect for a short time.

### Attuned Wards Cormyrrian Battle Mage Utility 6

*You cover your nearby ally in an arcane cloak that offers protection from your attacks.*

**Encounter ♦ Arcane**

**Minor Action** **Close burst 2**

**Target:** One ally in the burst

**Effect:** The target takes no damage from your arcane attack powers until the end of your next turn.

## Level 10 Utility Power

Battle mages learn to bring ultimate destruction to their enemies. Channeling such enormous amounts of power places tremendous strain on the caster, so it takes a bit of time for you to recover from empowering a spell in this manner.

### Unleash Devastation Cormyrrian Battle Mage Utility 10

*You channel all your strength into one furious attack.*

**Daily ♦ Arcane**

**No Action** **Personal**

**Trigger:** You roll damage for an arcane attack power and dislike the result.

**Effect:** You reroll as many of the damage dice as you like, but you must use the second result.

### About the Author

**Dan Anderson** is the Living FORGOTTEN REALMS (LFR) writing director for the Calimshan story area and the Epic campaign. He has written several LFR adventures, including *Fury of the Queen of Thorns*, *Cracks in the Crimson Cage*, *The Menace of Memnon*, and *The Agony of Almraiven*. Dan also wrote the “Backdrop: Xiousing” article in the October 2011 issue of *Dungeon*.

**Developer**

**Tanis O'Connor**

**Editor**

**Miranda Horner**

**Managing Editors**

**Kim Mohan, Jeremy Crawford**

**Producers**

**Christopher Perkins, Greg Bilsland, Stan!**

**Digital Services Consultant**

**Dan Helmick**

**Art Directors**

**Kate Irwin, Jon Schindehette**

**Illustrators**

**William O'Connor, Claudio Pozas, Goran Josic**

**Graphic Production**

**Angie Lokotz**





# Crowns and Mantles

## The Ranks and Titles of Cormyr

By Brian Cortijo

Illustrations by Hector Ortiz and Claudio Pozas

*"I give my loyal service unfailingly to the Mage Royal of Cormyr, in full obedience of speech and action, that peace and order shall prevail in the Forest Kingdom, that magic of mine and others be used and not misused. I do this in trust that the Mage Royal shall unswervingly serve the throne of Cormyr, and if the Mage Royal should fall, or fail the Crown and Throne, my obedience shall be to the sovereign directly. Whenever there is doubt and dispute, I shall act to preserve Cormyr. Sunrise and moonfall, as long as my breath takes and my eyes see, I serve Cormyr. I pledge my life that the realm endure."*

*—The Oath of the War Wizard*

Titles, ranks, positions, and honors are awarded in Cormyr for services great and small. Some are of little consequence to adventurers, who usually have no interest in being named Underscribe of the Understair or Lord Keeper of the Virgin Wood. Other adventurers, however, might—through no fault of their own—end up working in the direct service of Cormyr and its monarch, King Foril. In doing so, they might be honored

with ranks or titles, or with positions of authority and command, especially as they rise to national importance and take on threats to the kingdom.

Descriptions of the most important of these titles appear below. Each bears with it duties, privileges, and adventuring opportunities that otherwise might be closed off to adventurers with less interest in serving Cormyr in an official capacity. Because few heroes might wish to be weighed down by such responsibility, the option exists to delay an appointment or investiture of nobility until after one's retirement.

## REGISTRATION AS TITLE

Even in the absence of a rank of honor or a title of nobility, most adventurers are already registered, in one form or another, with the Crown of Cormyr if they wish to operate within the kingdom. This registration carries certain responsibilities, but also grants certain rights.

## Chartered Adventurers

The most common form of registration is that of a chartered adventuring company. Once prohibitively expensive for all but the most successful of adventuring bands, a charter now costs a mere 25 gp (renewable annually) for a party of between five and thirty adventurers, although the Crown encourages groups of more than a dozen to register as mercenary

bands. A charter for adventuring permits the bearers to wield and carry weapons openly—although they must still obey laws of peace-bonding weapons within cities and towns—as well as allowing the heroes to accept contracts for defense of legitimate persons. A company that fails to renew is declared outlaw and can be hunted down by any chartered company. Successful adventuring companies can seek a full royal charter, signed by the king's hand. Such charters cost upward of 1,000 gp.

Any adventuring company can, by royal decree, have its charter revoked for treason or other crimes. More often, the Crown raises the charter renewal levy so high that the company cannot afford its fee, and its members must disband or become outlaws.

### Mercenary Companies

Typically larger than a chartered adventuring band, a mercenary company has the same rights as one, is permitted to maintain a larger roll of members (thirty standing members, plus up to one hundred recruits in times of crisis), and has more latitude in recruitment and reporting to the Crown. The price for this freedom is steep: 20,000 gp for the initial charter, with an annual renewal fee of 3,000 gp (plus 25 gp for each individual who was temporarily recruited over the last year).

### Registered Mages

Every wizard, sorcerer, warlock, or anyone else capable of casting powerful, destructive spells of arcane magic must register with a local lord, a herald, or the War Wizards. Registered spellcasters are allowed to practice openly and can be approached by the Crown for research, hired spellcasting, other assignments or recruitment into the War Wizards. Registered mages can attend the monthly meetings of the Council of Mages, and those who acquit themselves well might be asked to join the Mage Councilors.

A spellcaster who refuses to register can function legally without fear of punishment, but such a person who is found to have slain another with magic, or otherwise broken Cormyr's laws, can be marked a renegade mage. Such individuals are hunted with impunity by the War Wizards, and can be captured by chartered adventurers and registered spellcasters without fear of Crown reprisal.

Spellcasters who are members of a chartered adventuring band are automatically registered under the group's charter, and need not fear the War Wizards seeking them out.

### KNOW THE LAND

The titles in this article are presented with their current holders named, if those positions are filled. This is not to suggest that a worthy, ambitious servant of the Dragon Throne might not succeed one of these nobles. A number of officers of the realm are on the cusp of retirement, and mishap or treachery might cause other positions to open up.

Whether for the sake of supplanting an existing noble or just learning the landscape, every social climber and worthy noble knows who holds power, who is higher than whom on society's ladder, and the best means of climbing it oneself. An officer of Cormyr would do well to learn the significance of the important titles, and be aware of whom to obey when the time comes.

Politics is a dangerous business, and don't doubt for a moment that the Cormyrean military and its War Wizards are political arenas just as much as the Royal Court.

## TITLES OF NOBILITY

At the top of the pyramid of title and privilege in Cormyr is the nobility: the heredity bearers of authority of the realm, charged with safeguarding its people and serving its crowned heads.

### Duties and Privileges

Nobility carries with it a number of benefits. Nobles can keep armed retinues (the extent of which is determined by the family, the title, when it was issued, and the relevant royal proclamations), maintain fortified residences, hire mercenary bands, pass heraldic blazons to their children, and serve as de facto officers in the Purple Dragons. They have the power to detain or arrest—but not to put on trial or punish—commoners who commit crimes on their lands or in their presence, as well as the ability to petition and advise the Crown directly, without the need to find an advocate at Court. Unlike common Cormyreans, nobles can walk with weapons unbonded, although this is customarily seen with decorative court swords and not true, battle-ready blades.

In return for these rights and privileges, every noble must swear fealty directly to both the monarch and the Crown. He or she must maintain a retinue for conscription into the Purple Dragons, in addition to being prepared to serve actively (or to fund an appropriate body of soldiers). Nobles also pay taxes to the Crown based on the expected level of wealth for their station and holdings; rather than being subject to the “indignity” of a visit from the royal exchequer, each noble is assigned a sum (which of course all nobles consider far too high) that he or she must pay the Crown's coffers.

Nobles do not have the right to swear individuals to their personal service or the service of their families, nor can they accept oaths of fealty from other nobles.



## Titles

The nobility of Cormyr is organized into a loose hierarchy consisting of several distinct ranks, which are granted by the monarch. Although familial loyalties, debts of honor, property or service, and binding contracts require nobles to fulfill an obligation to their fellows, none are permitted to swear oaths of fealty to any but the king.

In earlier generations, when nobles were entitled to amass their own personal armies, their titles delineated just how large a force an individual family might muster. Now, though the hierarchy remains, it has little real impact on just how powerful a family is (that is, of course, outside social circles).

The nobles of Cormyr owe their fealty to the monarch of the realm, currently King Foril Obarskyr. A female monarch is known as a **queen**, as is the wife of a king (a ruling queen's husband is a **prince-consort**). Their children are the princes and princesses of the kingdom, with the heir apparent being known as the crown prince or crown princess. The reigning monarch might wear any number of crowns at different times (there have been a large number of crowns throughout Cormyr's history), but the favored is the three-spined golden Crown of Rhiiman, each spire with an amethyst set onto it. The immediate heir to the throne, by ancient tradition, wears only a simple, golden circlet. The current heir to the throne is Crown Prince Irvell Obarskyr.

Below the royal family are the dukes and duchesses of the realm. Even influential nobles almost never attain this rank, which is usually reserved for relatives of the monarch (including the heads of Houses Truesilver and Crownsilver, who hold ancient blood ties to the Crown). Occasionally, however, a great hero might be raised to the title of duke, with a lesser title being passed to his offspring. When Crown Prince Irvell's son Baerovus ascends the Dragon Throne after his father, his sister Princess Raedra will be known as duchess royal, as will any

other princes and princesses of the realm who do not rule. At present, in addition to the royal houses, only the heads of House Illance and House Marliir hold the rank of duke.

Immediately below these nobles are the ranks of marchion and marchioness. Granted more rarely than the rank of duke, they are traditionally bestowed upon nobles that serve the crown as frontier lords in dangerous territories—a sort of service that Cormyr has not truly required for years. The acquisition of such a noble title is considered to be a great honor, though the heirs to the peerage created by the rank are invariably of a lesser rank, usually earls or barons, rather than inheriting the full rank of their invested parents.

Next lower in the social hierarchy are the earls (never “counts,” because of possible confusion with the title “corount”) and countesses (who are addressed as “Lady,” except by heralds and court scribes), who make up a goodly number of the eldest noble houses of the realm. Those families that trace their claims of nobility to other kingdoms, namely Marsembler or Esparin, were once ranked as counts, but this usage has since died out along with the families that bore the titles.

Viscounts and viscountesses sit below the earls of the kingdom, with barons and baronesses below them.

The next lower in the hierarchy are baronets and baronetesses. Noble houses more than three generations old are populated by more nobles of this rank than any other, thanks to the means by which noble titles are distributed after the death of a title-holder.

At the bottom of the noble ranks is the knight. This title is applied to both men and women, but as a form of address, females are styled “Lady Knight.” Knights do not inherit their titles, nor do they pass them to their offspring; a knighthood is earned through service to the Crown. Although knights do not gain the markers of rank of true nobles, they are officers of the Purple Dragons, with the ability to command

obedience as a swordcaptain that outranks the higher baronets.

Titles below the rank of duke are associated with a specific region of Cormyr or its immediate environs. Although this association brings no true authority over that region, most nobles make a token attempt to maintain a residence, or at least a small building to use as a retreat, within the nominal area of their realms.

## Family Rulership

Within each named family—regardless of how many members of a given house hold noble titles of their own—the members answer to a single, recognized head who is formally responsible before the Crown for the family's actions. The head of a noble house is treated with respect by officials of the realm and by other nobles, effectively honoring the noble as though he possessed a title one rank higher. The head of a house is the most direct descendant of the house's founder and does not necessarily hold the highest noble rank in a given house.

It is possible for noble houses to fracture, particularly when a younger line of the house is elevated to a higher rank of nobility. In such cases, either the house must recognize the new titleholder as the lord or lady of the family, or the newly elevated noble must separate and found a new house, with a new name to be presented at Court.

## Extraordinary Titles

The Crown frequently creates titles that cannot be passed on to descendants or other inheritors. Such grants, known as extraordinary titles, do not persist beyond the death of the bearer. These titles are the customary means of rewarding nonhuman servants of the kingdom, who cannot truly be accepted by the human nobility (due to longevity, odd abilities, or sheer racism), but are willing to accept the honor of being named a trusted defender of the Crown.

## On Matters of Inheritance

A hereditary noble's title is affected most strongly by the circumstances of that noble's birth: the rank of the parent holding the relevant title, the order of birth, and the family's position with the Crown. Until they ascend to a title in their own right (by the death of a relative or a direct award of a title), nobles are treated as possessors of a courtesy title one or more ranks lower than that of the noble parent: the first children of dukes and marchions are earls and countesses; the first children of earls are viscounts; the first

children of viscounts are barons; and the first children of barons are baronets, with descending titles for younger children based on the various included titles of the parent.

When a noble dies, his or her titles pass to the children, in roughly the same order that their courtesy titles were assigned (a number of royal grants have special terms by which this is done). When the direct heir assumes the title of the deceased parent and ascends in rank, younger children officially assume the rank which they held in courtesy while their parent lived. Over generations, this process repeats, such that most members of a given noble family are ranked as baronets, with other titles distributed among the various branches of the house.

and file of the Purple Dragons first obey their immediate superiors, and follow the lead of firstswords and swordcaptains in determining whether the noble barking orders has the necessary wits to command soldiers. Crownsilver, Illance, Rowanmantle, and Truesilver nobles are usually esteemed above their rank by the Dragons around them. In contrast, the Dracohorns are currently so poorly regarded by Cormyr's soldiery that, if placed at the head of an army, they might be giving orders to companies of men afflicted with selective deafness.

## MILITARY HIERARCHY

Joining Cormyr's military is a simple affair: show up, demonstrate the ability to march in armor and swing a weapon competently, and take an oath. Unlike with the nobility, the ranks of the Purple Dragons are a straightforward vertical organization, in which each person knows to whom he or she answers.

## Service and Sacrifice

Purple Dragons are expected to fight and, if necessary, die for the Forest Kingdom. Those who serve in the armies of Cormyr do so on a year-round basis, engaging in regular skirmishes with humanoid bands and roving bandits, training in the kingdom's forts, or policing the streets of its cities and towns.

Some of the membership serves on detached duty, ready to be called back into service at a moment's notice, but otherwise free to pursue other, more specialized missions in the service of the Crown, whether it be in the company of a highknight or a War Wizard, as the bodyguard to a noble or envoy, or as part of an elite cadre of Crown agents in service to the Court. Such adventuring Purple Dragons are rare, but they do exist, and among them are numbered some of the greatest (if unsung) heroes of the realm.

### BY ANY OTHER NAME

The titles of nobility presented here are given in the Common tongue. Most Cormyreans speak Chondathan as well. Presented here are the equivalent ranks in the Chondathan language.

King: Astrel ("Az-trell")

Queen: Araunna ("Arr-awn-ah")

Prince: Ardyr ("Ar-deer")

Princess: Ardess ("Ar-dess")

Duke: Storn

Duchess: Staerra ("Stair-ah")

Marchion: Mahrsar ("Mar-sarr")

Marchioness: Mahrsara

Earl: Velm ("Vel-mm")

Countess: Velana ("Vell-anna")

Viscount: Tlarvelm ("Tah-lar-velm")

Viscountess: Tlarvelana ("Tah-lar-velanna")

Baron (in Cormyr, includes Baronet): Taen ("Tayn")

Baroness (in Cormyr, includes Baronetess): Taenya ("Tay-nyah")

Knight: Tahar ("Tah-har")

Lord: Aro ("Air-o")

Lady: Arauna ("Air-on-ah")

Sir: Saer ("Say-ur")

## Markers and Symbols

In addition to the heraldic devices possessed by every noble family, each noble who holds a title in his or her own right (that is, a noble who carries a true title, and not a courtesy title from a relative) also possesses a crown of rank. This crown is a two-spired circlet of steel, onto which are welded different ornaments to delineate increased rank. Higher-titled nobles have their crowns plated in silver, and later gilded, to mark their status.

## Nobles and the Purple Dragons

Nobles, by virtue of their rank and position, hold authority over the Purple Dragons in time of war or crisis. The rank and file must obey nobles as though they were swordcaptains, because the nobles by definition hold a title of at least baronet. Earls hold the authority of ornrions, as do the heads of the noble houses. Dukes of the realm command with the authority of overswords.

Actual, ranked officers hold greater authority than nobles of "equivalent" rank, but in practice, the rank



## Through the Ranks

Rank-and-file Purple Dragons begin their tenure as blades, or typical foot soldiers. Blades have no authority of their own beyond the power to make arrests or challenge intruders while on duty. A veteran blade, or a Purple Dragon who has experience as a mercenary or an adventurer, can be awarded the rank of telsword, with the power to lead small patrols of up to half a dozen blades.

A firstsword is the senior soldier and leader of a small force (typically fewer than a dozen, though it can number as high as twenty). A firstsword has the authority to make reports, give testimony, disarm and detain unchartered adventurers, and otherwise operate without strict supervision.

Serving under royal warrant, the swordcaptain is the lowest rank of officer in the Purple Dragons. Swordcaptains serve as the heads of companies of soldiers, as lieutenants to commissioned officers, as patrol captains and shift officers, and in any number of other roles within the military. Swordcaptains have the right to wear weapons unbound when they're not on official duty, and can swear soldiers into the service of the Crown. They also have the power to promote a blade to the rank of telsword, and to recommend the promotion of a telsword to firstsword.

Lionar is the lowest commissioned rank in the army of the Purple Dragon, and it is a position of great trust. In addition to commanding over one hundred soldiers trained to fight for the realm, lionars can promote or strip of rank any subordinate Purple Dragon (although, in the case of a swordcaptain, only on a temporary basis), can accept soldiers into service, and can requisition from the Crown additional supplies of food, tents, and weapons.

An ornrion is an officer of middling rank, often assigned as a lieutenant to a higher-ranking officer or as a commander over a larger company of Purple Dragons. Ornrions can issue warrants of swordcaptaincy, can strip such warrants, and can deny pay—or



expel entirely—Purple Dragons for offenses against their fellows.

Officers of high rank, constals command full brigades of troops, and are either of noble birth or invested with a title of full nobility before being assigned such a weighty task. A constal can issue and strip commissions of lower officers, and can overturn the decisions of lesser officers.

The general officers of the realm use two ranks: the older oversword and the newer, more elevated battlemaster. Although battlemasters are formally above overswords in the ranking structure, overswords serve as garrison commanders and leaders of fortifications, whereas battlemasters are responsible for the handling of mobile troops and the gathering of disparate companies into cohesive armies during times of war. An oversword or a battlemaster has the authority to execute a member of the Purple Dragons for mutiny, and to bring charges of desertion against nobles serving with their armies.

Within the kingdom, wardship or another military title is given over different regions of the nation. Currently, the Eastern Marches (which include Hul-lack, the area around Tilverton, and the area east of Arabel) are protected by the Warden of the Eastern Marches. The Warden answers only to the king and to the High Marshal of the realm. The current Warden is Warvred Emmarask, who operates out of Castle Crag, and was dubbed an earl when he was assigned the post by King Foril.

There was rumor of such a post being created for the Northern Marches (to include, among other areas, the Goblin Marches and the Stonelands) under the kings Azoun IV and V, but this has never come to pass.

The highest officer in the realm, answering only to the king, is High Marshal of the Kingdom. Currently, this position is filled by Crown Prince Irvell, who wears a variation of the High Marshal's badge on his tabard when he rides at the head of a Purple Dragon patrol.

### Markers and Symbols

The Purple Dragons wear a basic uniform composed of a white tabard emblazoned with the purple dragon device of Cormyr. On the left shoulder is embroidered a shield-shaped badge depicting the soldier's rank, which is sewn and outlined so that it is clearly visible and recognizable from a short distance. Other markers—such as a company badge, or representations of honors received by a soldier—appear on the left breast, above the edge of the shield device. The nation's navy, the Blue Dragons, uses the same ranks as the army does, although most sailors are telswords, and swordcaptains are not often present on board ships. The Blue Dragons use a blue dragon device on their tabards, which are seldom worn except in port.

Nobles who are serving with the Purple Dragons (with or without formal rank) have war helms specially constructed to represent their crown of noble title, so they are easily recognized in the chaos of the battlefield.

### WIZARDLY RANKS AND TITLES

Wizards and other arcane casters abound in Cormyr, whether occupied in shoring up its defenses, creating magic items, or inadvertently unleashing ancient, unspeakable horrors upon the populace. Cormyr is a land of magic, and its inhabitants long ago learned to honor—and fear—the power that magic brings its wielders.

### War Wizards

The Brotherhood of Wizards of War is the spellcasting arm of Cormyr's defense. The War Wizards' numbers are not known accurately by any living beings except Ganrahas and Lord Warder Vainrence. It is suspected that the group now numbers between five hundred and twelve hundred mages.

Given that War Wizards perform so many different functions—from research and item creation, to the reinforcement of palace wards, to espionage,

### TITLES AND ADVENTURING PARTIES

Player characters represent the rarest of beings, individuals of great personal power who amass influence and wealth at a far greater rate than others. Because of this fact, as the Crown recognizes their contributions to the realm and seeks to reward and maintain their loyalty and service, adventurers can easily rise in rank or gather titles.

Although these ranks can be used as powerful story awards, great care should be taken not to allow a granted title to disrupt the flow of gameplay. Ranks and titles are meant to enrich roleplaying opportunities, not to allow one character to literally lord over the people he or she encounters. If multiple members of a single party possess different ranks or titles from the Crown, that state of affairs can create interesting situations and social encounters, but the game shouldn't be permitted to descend into player debates about whose title outstrips the others.

For example, it's entirely feasible to have a party with a lionar warlord, a War Wizard, a highknight rogue, and a fighter who is a member of a noble house. Whereas the noble's access or the War Wizard's responsibilities might open doors for the group, and the lionar might have troops at his command, there's nothing heroic about spending an entire gaming session debating who is "in charge."

Unless, of course, your group enjoys that sort of thing, in which case, have at it! Just remember to keep the debates in character.



to battlefield aid—any attempts to narrow the estimate are too speculative to be of any real use. Since Foril's reign began, an increasing number of sword-mages have joined the brotherhood, leading to a more military bent to its philosophies and operations.

The War Wizards have no outwardly discernible hierarchy of command. Each War Wizard knows to whom he or she answers thanks to the meticulously worded commands of their superiors, the Royal Magician and the Lord Warder. They stand outside the chain of command of the Purple Dragons, even when attached directly to a unit, and can be called away from that group on more urgent matters at a moment's notice.

### Alarphons

The only formal rank within the War Wizards is that of alarphon. The internal investigators of the War Wizards, alarphons are empowered to ask questions and engage in magical interrogation of their own number in order to ferret out treachery and learn whether other members of the brotherhood have not been forthcoming with information important to the protection of the realm. Whether this reluctance is due to perfidy or mere stupidity, sometimes the realm must be defended from its own protectors, and the alarphons are charged with that defense.

### Lord Warder

The first recipient of this new title under Royal Magician Ganrahas, Lord Warder Vainrence is the battlefield commander of the War Wizards, reinforcing the brotherhood's new role in the active defense of the realm. The Lord Warder answers to the Royal Magician, to the Court Wizard (if different from the Royal Magician), and to the Crown; in military matters, the Lord Warder also submits to the High Marshal.

## Royal Magician

In his capacity as Royal Magician or Mage Royal—but never “royal mage”—Ganrahas is responsible for the overall magical well-being of the realm, the defense of the royal family (including the construction of magical wards for the palace), providing advice to the monarch, and seeing to the proper education of future rulers. He is also the absolute authority on issues of magical use in Cormyr, and the commanders of the War Wizards are subordinate to him.

Although Royal Magician is not officially a hereditary title, all of Cormyr's mages royal have been descendants of the first Royal Magician, Baerauble Etharr, and his eladrin bride, Alea Dahast. The only possible exception to this succession—depending on whom you believe—was Caladnei, who came into the position after her appointment by Vangerdahast. In spite of rumors about Caladnei's true lineage, in the whole of Cormyr's history, only three decades have seen a Mage Royal not of Baerauble's line.

## Mage Councilors

The Council of Mages meets on the fourteenth day of each month at the Royal Court in Suzail. At each meeting, royal proclamations relevant to the use of magic are made public, matters of employment for workers of magic are discussed, and mages—including the War Wizards—accept inquiries for service or advertise their need for the assistance of other spellcasters.

The mages councilor of the kingdom are selected from among the wisest and most capable wizards, sorcerers, swordmages, and other registered arcane spellcasters of Cormyr. The council also advises the king, through the office of Court Wizard.

## Court Wizard

The Court Wizard oversees the Council of Mages. He or she is responsible for its operation, the appointment of new members to the group, the registration of mages in the Forest Kingdom, and advising the Crown on matters of magical concern. Because the War Wizards fall under the authority of the Council of Mages, the Court Wizard is also responsible for selecting its commander, who then reports to the Royal Magician.

To add to the complexity, the Court Wizard is bound to obey the king and his family (spouse and children), whereas the Mage Royal answers only to the king and the Court Wizard. This conflict of authority has meant that most Royal Magicians have officially served as Court Wizard as well. Except during a brief period in his youth, Royal Magician Ganrahas has also been Court Wizard, and so owes his obedience only to King Foril.

## SPIES AND AGENTS

The Crown engages any number of individual agents, spies, courtiers, informants, and observers to protect its interests and the safety of the realm. Although most loyal servants go unheralded or die unnoticed in pursuit of missions for the Dragon Throne, one group is officially known and bears the formal authority of the king when it investigates matters.

Although it is not technically a rank of nobility, highknight is a title devised by Vangerdahast and Filfaeril, created during the reign of Azoun IV. It is a rank of service, denoting the faith of the Crown in the recipient and the loyalty of the individual receiving it. Each highknight is also a knight of the realm—and entitled to the privileges that title carries—but can command obedience from knights as well as commoners. A highknight can question any subject of the realm, including the highest nobles, and accuse (with evidence) anyone of a crime.



### SLANG AND EPITHETS

A great number of insults, compliments, and oaths have been formed over the years in response to various shifts in titles and rank. A few slang terms currently in use by, or employed in reference to, servants of the realm include these.

**Count:** A defunct title, equivalent in rank to earl. Now used derisively to refer to the useless husband of a noblewoman of any rank.

**Highnose:** An effete or snooty noble.

**Lackshield:** A Purple Dragon that has been stripped of rank. Or, a noble in command of Purple Dragons who holds no true rank.

**Oldblood:** Said of a noble house of great age and respected reputation.

**Red Dragon:** A traitor to the kingdom (from the device of Salembur, the Rebel Prince).

**Swordlord:** A respected Purple Dragon officer (or a noble serving as commander of Purple Dragons); used to elevate the subject in the eyes of the listener.

**Spellbeggar:** A War Wizard's insulting term for clerics and other divine spellcasters.

### POSITIONAL AND UNIQUE TITLES

Woven throughout the levels of hierarchy in Cormyr are a number of posts, appointments, and unique titles that interact with the officers and nobles of the realm, standing outside their circles but nonetheless holding influence over them.

### King's Lords

Scattered across the realm are cities, towns, and smaller settlements ruled by the King's Lords—those people appointed as governors, to speak for the Crown, dispense justice, collect taxes, and organize the defense of the realm. A noble of at least baron rank (whether inherited or appointed), a King's Lord is the ultimate authority in a governed area, overseeing trials of accused criminals, appointing guard captains and other officers, and otherwise making sure that King Foril's will is carried out.

### Heralds

Each lord is aided in his or her ("Lord" is applied to both male and female holders of the post) duties by an appointed herald. Not to be confused with the High Heralds, who maintain the proper succession of titles across Faerûn, these officials are responsible for keeping the lord's records of taxation, births, and deaths; the licensing of certain merchants and businesses; the registration of local mages; and the distribution of pay to the lord's guards, garrisons, and clerks. From time to time an experienced herald is elevated to lord of his or her city or town because of the intimate knowledge that individual possesses of the region.

### Lord Commanders

The highest resident officers at their respective fortifications, the lord commanders of the kingdom are responsible for the upkeep and maintenance of the realm's castles and forts, the welfare of the men garrisoned there, and the proper defense of the passes and roads over which they are meant to guard. Oversword Raoulas Cormaeril, Lord Commander of High Horn Hold, holds the most coveted of these posts.

### Baron of the Stonelands

For more than one hundred years, the Dragon Throne has promised the title Baron of the Stonelands to anyone that can fortify a keep in the Stonelands, maintain a retinue of armed soldiers, and prove—through the capture or slaying of bandits and killing of humanoids and monsters—that they can defend a parcel of the region for at least a full year. The reward for this endeavor is great: the formal title of baron and the equivalent rank of oversword in the Purple Dragons, with a hefty stipend to maintain their outpost. To date, none have succeeded, and no one has tried for more than two decades.

### Court Titles

More than one hundred unique court titles are assigned to various pages, officers, clerks, and other staff at the Royal Court or working in the Palace of the Purple Dragon. Most people see little honor in the titles of royal cellarer, protocol chamberlain, chatelaine, or seneschal, but these people are vital to the maintenance of the realm's grandeur. One such court title, however, has vastly increased in influence over the last three hundred years.

### Royal Sage Most Learned

Over the last few centuries, no title has grown in importance or prestige as has the Royal Sage Most Learned to the Royal Court. Officially, the Sage is the kingdom's expert on law, history, and languages—and each of the Sages has performed that task admirably. Unofficially, the Royal Sage has become one of the most trusted advisors to the Crown, advising on matters of diplomacy and etiquette, as well as studying more obscure bits of magical history and lore to better understand the wards protecting the royal buildings.

The current Royal Sage Most Learned is Ossani Eveningspire.

### Defender

This special honorific is granted by the Crown to elevate the bearer to a special status: a noble who has formal military rank as well. Although a defender might conceivably hold any particular noble and military rank, in practice, a typical holder of the title is both a baron of the realm and a constable of the Purple Dragons.

### Corount

Among oldest words the Common tongue, a corount is an officer—either a courtier or military commander—temporarily elevated to the ranks of the nobility by the Crown after the rightful holder of the title has suddenly died, gone missing, or become incapacitated, and the throne wishes to investigate before assigning a successor or more permanent replacement. Effectively a form of regency for a noble house, only trusted agents are named corounts, to ensure that the appointment is truly temporary.

#### *About the Author*

**Brian Cortijo** is a freelance game designer and fiction author who's been playing in the backroads and underhalls of Cormyr for years, and is thrilled to finally bring some of that work to light. His thanks, as always, go out to Ed Greenwood, for the Realms, and for trusting him with the sandbox (and especially the shinier toys).

#### Editor

**Chris Winters**

#### Managing Editor

**Kim Mohan**

#### Producers

**Christopher Perkins, Greg Bilsland, Stan!**

#### Art Directors

**Kate Irwin, Jon Schindehette**

#### Illustrators

**Hector Ortiz, Claudio Pozas**

#### Graphic Production

**Angie Lokotz**





# Blades of Kings

## The Cormyrean Swords of State

By Brian Cortijo

Illustration by Hector Ortiz

Every nation worthy of the name has its swords of kingship. Tethyr, Impiltur, elven Myth Drannor, and the undersea realms as well . . . even some of the petty baronies of the Border Kingdoms boast blades whose ownership proves the right to rule. Cormyr is blessed with four such weapons—and two others besides if they are ever found. Many warriors hope for the chance to wield such fine steel once in their lives, or they hope to cut down those foolish enough to try to raid the royal grounds and escape with these blades. Still others seek the Lost Blades avidly so that they can better serve the Forest Kingdom or strike down the Obarskyr line and claim the Dragon Throne themselves.

### THE FOUR SWORDS

The four Swords of State rest in the Shrine of the Four Swords, which is down the long public corridor from the Chamber of the Purple Dragon in the Royal Court (see “Cormyr Royale” in *Dungeon* 198 for details about the shrine). The swords rest on raised, velvet-covered plinths beneath magic crystal domes that sound out alarms in certain circumstances. Each is sheathed in a fine scabbard that is decorated with exquisite, expertly cut sapphires. People come to pray beside the swords, whispering secret desires and asking for guidance, fortitude, or luck in upcoming endeavors.

Each of the royal blades has its own function and duty. *Ansrivarr* is as old as the realm, and it represents the endurance of the kingdom and its royal

line. *Orbyn* is the blade of the nation’s warrior-kings, on which all oaths of evidence before the Crown are sworn. *Rissar* serves as the blade over which blood oaths and oaths of marriage are sworn. *Symylazarr* is Cormyr’s Font of Honor, used to raise nobles and honor the service of knights.

The four swords are clearly weapons of exceptional make and magical power, but some believe they are artifacts bound to Cormyr’s past and future: items that cannot be altered by any known means. Damaging or destroying them requires immense effort and will bring about the vengeance of House Obarskyr and loyal Cormyreans once they learn of the deed.

One of the Swords of State could fall into an adventurer’s hands in a number of ways. An adventurer could defeat a thief that escaped with the weapon; he or she could be forced to take up one of the blades during an attack on the Royal Court; or one might use trickery to steal the weapon from the shrine. Only a blood Obarskyr, or one who is approved by the Crown directly (as are the Royal Magician and the Lord Warder, and—it is presumed—the future spouses of Prince Baerovus and Princess Raedra), may remove one of the swords without punishment.

Claiming one of the Swords of State is not as simple as wresting it from the hands of its current wielder, and taking advantage of its powers or its value in gold or *residium* is more difficult than selling or disenchanting the blade. The Crown of Cormyr holds these weapons among its greatest treasures,

and will do whatever it can to regain them: first by diplomacy, then by trade, and finally, if necessary, by violent means. Officials of Cormyr treat any of the Swords of State as rare items when determining their value for reward—or ransom—and they pay the full value of the magical properties (and possibly more, depending on the circumstances of the weapon's disappearance and recovery) to place the weapon back in Crown hands.

In addition to the generous stance the Dragon Throne takes in dealing with persons possessing a piece of its regalia, it is willing to trade weapons

obtained through heroic defense of the kingdom for one of the many swords in the fabled collection of the late King Azoun IV, who collected dozens of magic swords of various types and enchantments—including some that mirror or dwarf the powers of the Swords of State.

## Ansrivarr, Blade of Memory

Carried by Mondar Bleth from Old Impiltur when he and his family arrived in what would later become Suzail, this ancient, battered blade is older

than the realm. Taken up by Faerlthann First-King when Mondar was slain by the elves who then ruled Cormyr (though every tale told of the slaying blames the attack on orcs), *Ansrivarr* was the sword worn by Faerlthann and all his sons during their reigns. It was later replaced by finer steel blades crafted to each monarch's taste in successive generations, becoming little more than an object of ceremony. For generations, the only use for *Ansrivarr* has been in the coronation of Cormyr's kings.

Unknown to the Obarskyr kings, Baerauble Etharr and the elves of Iliphar's court (more specifically, Baerauble's beloved, Alea Dahast) wove countless protective enchantments into the blade, making it nigh invulnerable. Due to its being the sword that represents the kingdom, tale upon tale connects the fate of the realm to that of the blade, and every precaution was taken in those earliest days to prevent dire fates from coming to pass for the sword and the kingdom.

*Ansrivarr* is a +4 *staggering greatsword*.

## Orbyn, Edge of Justice

Forged by Amedahast for King Duar soon after the death of Baerauble and her ascension as High Mage, *Orbyn* is an exceptionally powerful weapon. Commonly referred to as "Orblyn" thanks to the speech impediment of a former king and the unwillingness of a scribe to contradict his liege, the sword is used to swear oaths of evidence at the Royal Court and to execute nobles guilty of capital crimes. It is also widely accepted as the proper blade of kings.

*Orbyn* is a finely crafted longsword with intricate, barely visible runes trailing up and down its blade; those holding the sword have noted that the runes seem to move. It has defeated many threats to the Crown, including Magrath the Minotaur—the pirate captain that took Suzail from Duar—and the ancient Thauglor, from whom the Purple Dragons take their name.

*Orbyn* is a +5 *shearing longsword*.

## EXPANDING ON THE SWORDS OF STATE

The powers attributed to each of the weapons in this article assumes that they are "mere" magic swords that happen to be tied to Cormyr's history. You might, however, decide that the rumors about one or more of these blades are true and want them to possess the greater power of an artifact.

If you do present one of the weapons as an artifact, you can add powers to the individual swords as best fits your ongoing campaign. There are, however, certain powers that some of the blades are rumored to possess or that have not come into play since before the Spellplague struck.

### Rumored Abilities

- ◆ *Ilbratha*, Mistress of Battles, received its epithet not only for its leaping ability, but because of its ability to create a *mirror image* (as the wizard spell) of the wielder. Some tales describe how the sword permits the wielder to blink between the Feywild and the material world.
- ◆ When held by a blood Obarskyr, *Orbyn* can detect any untruths spoken by someone who touches the bared blade of the sword, as if the

person is affected by the Discern Lies ritual. A more dreadful rumor holds that one slain by *Orbyn* cannot be raised from the dead by any means short of the direct intervention of a deity.

- ◆ After swearing a blood oath over *Rissar*, the person swearing such an oath pays a terrible price for violating a vow. Until the violation is remedied, the oathmaker suffers a grievous, bleeding wound with every strike from the Wedding Blade.
- ◆ Gantharla's sword *Shiningbite* is said to have absorbed some power from Eaerdyannanscyg (pronounced "ee-air-din-ann-shig"), and it draws energy from the death of its victims, spouting draconic flame each time it takes a life.
- ◆ The runes of *Symylazarr* can relay a message to one who is carefully watching and who knows which symbol represents which ancient noble house. The runes glow faintly when a momentous occasion passes, emitting blue light for a noble birth, red for a noble death, and yellow for a betrayal of the Crown. The light persists for only a matter of seconds, and it often goes unmarked by onlookers.



## Shearing Weapon

Level 17+ Uncommon

*This weapon slices through even the most powerful of defenses.*

Lvl 17 +4 65,000 gp Lvl 27 +6 1,625,000 gp

Lvl 22 +5 325,000 gp

**Weapon:** Axe, heavy blade

**Enhancement Bonus:** Attack rolls and damage rolls

**Critical:** +1d8 damage per plus

**Utility Power** ♦ **Daily** (Minor Action)

**Effect:** The next attack you make with this weapon before the end of your next turn ignores the target's resistances. Until the end of the encounter, your attacks with this weapon ignore 5 points of any resistance. Level 22 or 27: 10 points of any resistance.

## Rissar, the Wedding Blade

Initially commissioned by crown prince Rhiigard (Rhiigard I, the Mourning King), Rissar is an exquisitely crafted short sword with a fortune's worth of gemstones set into its pommel and hilt. Rhiigard intended for the blade to be a wedding gift to Princess Aliia of Impiltur—one of many gifts he purchased, crafted, or had made for his betrothed. Upon hearing the news of her death, and twice afterward, Rhiigard briefly considered slaying himself on the sword's point, until he finally locked the weapon away deep in a royal vault. He placed it far enough from his sight to prevent it from reminding him of his grief and thus the temptation to end his life.

The Wedding Blade did not again see the light of day until the Year of the Emptied Lair (973 DR), when the contents of the vault in which it had been hidden were emptied and transferred to another chamber in the palace due to a rat infestation. The royal exchequer responsible for the transfer of the vault in question brought the blade to the attention of Bryntharth, who appropriated it for use during his wedding ceremony later that season, not knowing of its significance to his father. Rhiigard was appalled by its appearance in his son's hand, to say nothing of the most important of court ceremonies: the marriage of a crown prince. To save face, and to

mask his renewed grief, the king feigned pleasure at his son's discovery and proclaimed that from that moment forward all royal weddings would be sworn over the blade.

Rissar did not see use in swearing blood oaths until the reign of Pryntaler, who was notoriously fond of extracting blood oaths from his friends and vassals. It was Dhalmass who, in royal proclamation, decreed that the blood for any oaths sworn at court be drawn by Rissar's point.

Rissar is a +2 gleaming short sword.

## Gleaming Weapon

Level 9+ Uncommon

*The blade of this weapon shines like liquid silver.*

Lvl 9 +2 4,200 gp Lvl 24 +5 525,000 gp

Lvl 14 +3 21,000 gp Lvl 29 +6 2,625,000 gp

Lvl 19 +4 105,000 gp

**Weapon:** Axe, heavy blade, light blade

**Enhancement:** Attack rolls and damage rolls

**Critical:** +1d6 radiant damage per plus

**Attack Power** (Radiant) ♦ **Daily** (No Action)

**Trigger:** You hit a creature with a melee attack using this weapon.

**Effect:** The creature takes 1d6 radiant damage, and it is blinded until the end of your next turn.

Level 14 or 19: 2d6 radiant damage.

Level 24 or 29: 3d6 radiant damage.

## Symylazarr, Font of Honor

Symylazarr is a heavy hafted, broad-bladed war sword originally forged during the reign of Rhiiman the Glorious as a demonstration of the quality of weapon that the new steel works in Suzail could produce. Intended for display in one of the palace hallways, the sword bears an elaborate dragon's head pommel. Though lovely to look at, the blade's width and weight make it an unattractive weapon for actual fighting. Although it is not a comfortable weapon to wield, its blade is as sharp and deadly as when the sword was first forged.

The first time Symylazarr saw battle was nearly one hundred years after its forging, when Moriann

(then prince) was attacked by an assassin while walking the halls of Faerlthann's Keep. Moriann would have died were it not for the quick thinking of a servant named Varanth. The young man tore the sword from the wall and swung wildly at the would-be killer, which caused thunder to rumble. The strike he dealt tore the assassin's belly open and caused a fatal wound. Moriann knighted Varanth on the spot, and the former servant went on to gain the title "Thundersword" among palace guards. In addition to his new title, Varanth was allowed to keep the blade, which hung awkwardly from his small frame.

Varanth became one of the prince's fast friends, particularly when, a few months after the attempt on Moriann's life, the prince had the throne thrust upon him. Although neither a capable warrior nor a tactician of any skill, young "Thundersword" was made a commander in the king's army, always closely attached to any honor guard escorting the king. When Cormyr came into conflict with the goblin kingdom of Hlundadim, Varanth was among the first to fall, and the king took up his friend's sword, carrying it into battle on many occasions, and losing it in the fray almost as often. It was after the third battlefield knighting of warriors who had saved his life that Moriann forsook the use of the blade in combat.

Despite its unlucky tendencies in battle, Symylazarr is still an impressive ceremonial blade, and Moriann employed it in every knighting and investiture until his death. Each oath of fealty and allegiance was sworn over the blade, and in honor of those houses that took up his cause against Hlundadim, he had stylized runes of each family's initial and seal engraved upon the blade.

When Moriann died at the feast to celebrate Cormyr's successes against Hlundadim, Symylazarr was still strapped to the flank of his horse, and the sword was nearly buried with him. Rayn, Varanth's youngest son (the only one of six to survive the goblin wars), protested, saying that since the sword was given to



his father, it was his right to do with it as he pleased. Tharyann acquiesced, wary of such a popular young knight's gaining support against him even before he had taken the throne. Rayn took the sword and left.

He returned to the palace a tenday later, after Tharyann had ascended. Laying *Symylazarr* at the king's feet, Rayn swore his fealty and service to the king and his line, and he was invested as Lord Thundersword for his loyalty.

*Symylazarr* officially entered the royal regalia after the crowning of Gantharla, who declared that from her reign onward it would be used for all knighting and oaths of fealty to the crown. Its use fell dormant during the Thronestrife, but was restored by Thargreve the Greater, who used it to reestablish the loyalty of all of Cormyr's noble houses.

*Symylazarr* is a +3 *thundering bastard sword*.

## THE LOST BLADES

Still missing from the royal vaults and their proper shrine, *Ilbratha* and *Shiningbite* are honored in Cormyr's records as true pieces of the kingdom's regalia. Because both have been missing for centuries, the Dragon Throne would happily reward the finder of either of these weapons far beyond the value of the item.

Even more than the Four Swords, Cormyrean authorities are willing to negotiate for either of the Lost Blades. They will consider replacing the weapon with one of greater power from King Azoun's collection (which includes some uncommon and rare weapons of immense power), or duplicating the powers of *Ilbratha* or *Shiningbite* with rituals performed on another weapon of the bearer's choosing. If the sword was obtained by fighting traitors to the kingdom or from marauding humanoids, the Crown might even allow a wielder to carry the sword for a time, until—in the manner of Varanth—it is time to return it to Cormyr's rulers.

## Ilbratha, Mistress of Battles

Forged at the behest of Crown Prince (and later king) Azoun I, this bronze short sword retains a fine edge even after many battles. To Cormyreans, the Mistress of Battles is a symbol of Azoun's victory over the armies of Shoon, and of the glory and bounty lost when his ship, *Valashar's Bane*, sank into the Lake of Dragons in the Year of the Wooded Altar (389 DR).

For more than nine centuries, *Ilbratha* was called Haalorth, the Heir's Blade. It was carried by the heir of the undersea elven kingdom of Eadraal, and known to the sea folk as the Warrior's Fang. Lost during the Twelfth Serôs War (1369 DR), *Ilbratha*, and any trace of the weapon, disappeared entirely with the falling of the Sea of Fallen Stars during the Spellplague.

If found, *Ilbratha* would be considered the property of the heirs of both Cormyr and Eadraal, and part of the regalia of both nations. Eadraal's royal line is broken since the ravages of the Spellplague, but Cormyr still seeks the Mistress of Battles, if half-heartedly.

*Ilbratha* is a +2 *leaping short sword*.

| Leaping Weapon                                                                                                                                   |    |           | Level 8+ Uncommon |    |              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|-----------|-------------------|----|--------------|
| <i>The blade seems light, as if it wants to jump away.</i>                                                                                       |    |           |                   |    |              |
| Lvl 8                                                                                                                                            | +2 | 3,400 gp  | Lvl 23            | +5 | 425,000 gp   |
| Lvl 13                                                                                                                                           | +3 | 17,000 gp | Lvl 28            | +6 | 2,125,000 gp |
| Lvl 18                                                                                                                                           | +4 | 85,000 gp |                   |    |              |
| <b>Weapon:</b> Any one-handed melee                                                                                                              |    |           |                   |    |              |
| <b>Enhancement:</b> Attack rolls and damage rolls                                                                                                |    |           |                   |    |              |
| <b>Critical:</b> +1d6 damage per plus                                                                                                            |    |           |                   |    |              |
| <b>Attack Power</b> ♦ <b>Encounter</b> (Standard Action)                                                                                         |    |           |                   |    |              |
| <i>Effect:</i> You charge and can fly as part of the charge's movement. The number of squares you can fly equals the weapon's enhancement bonus. |    |           |                   |    |              |

## Shiningbite, the Drake's Tooth

This once-simple longsword was discovered in the royal armories by a youthful Gantharla, who ordered it polished and its hilt replaced before she carried it into the western reaches of Cormyr against encroaching lizardfolk from the Tun and Farsea marshes. Its recrafting included the addition of two of the rear teeth of the dragon Eardynnszczyg, who is also called Eardynn ("ee-ar-din"), at the ends of the crossguard, lending the wyrm's power and some of its legend to the blade.

Twice *Shiningbite* was used by the warrior-queen to fell young dragons in the Stormhorns, but its magic was not nearly so useful in her campaign against the hill giants in the west, who slew Gantharla and her entire band of ranger-knights, then stripped the bodies of anything that looked useful—including the Drake's Tooth. Where the blade passed after the First-Queen's death is a mystery.

*Shiningbite* is a +3 *true dragonslayer longsword*.

### About the Author

**Brian Cortijo** is a freelance game designer and fiction author who's been playing in the backroads and underhalls of Cormyr for years, and he is thrilled to bring some of that work to light. His thanks, as always, go out to Ed Greenwood, for the Realms, and for trusting him with the sandbox (and especially the shinier toys).

Developer  
**Tanis O'Connor**

Editor  
**Miranda Horner**

Managing Editors  
**Kim Mohan,**  
**Jeremy Crawford**

Producers  
**Christopher Perkins,**  
**Greg Bilsland, Stan!**

Digital Studio Consultant  
**Dan Helmick**

Art Directors  
**Kate Irwin,**  
**Jon Schindehette**

Illustrator  
**Hector Ortiz**

Graphic Production  
**Angie Lokotz**